POPULATION AND ETHNICITY

The ethnicity issue in Myanmar has been a constant source of turmoil throughout the history of the region. The term “ethnicity” rather than “tribe” or “nation” can lead to confusion and possible political conflict. Myanmar has approximately 130 different ethnic groups, with their own languages and dialects.

Myanmar is one of the most ethnically diverse countries in the world. The geographical location of Myanmar has caused considerable diffusion from India, China, Thailand, Bangladesh, and Laos. Ethnic minorities constitute over one-third of the entire population of Myanmar.

The most useful way to classify the culture of Myanmar would be along the plain or hill typology. The people of the plains live in the valleys or plains with a complex social and political organization that extends beyond the village. The centers of population are permanent and the main occupation is wet-rice farming. The plains' groups include the Burman (which make up 70% of the total population) along with the Shans, Mons, Arakanese, and delta Karen. The second significant classification would be mountain or hills' people. This hill culture consists of those who live in small units on the slopes or tops of hills, with relative autonomy and a simplistic political structure. Slash-and-burn agriculture would be commonly practiced. Included in this grouping would be Kachins, Chins, and hill Karen.

The largest nonindigenous groups are the Chinese and Indian minorities. Historically, these groups have been a vibrant part of the socioeconomic dynamic of the society. In contemporary times, immigration has been restricted, as the military-led government has drifted toward a more isolationist mindset. It should be noted that Burman refers to the ethnic group, while Burmese refers to the language that Burman people speak, as well as to the citizens of the country. The fact that Burmese is used so extensively in the writings about the country causes confusion at times.

Burman

The Burman (sometimes referred to as the Bamar) are not only the largest ethnic group in Myanmar, but they also have dominated the region